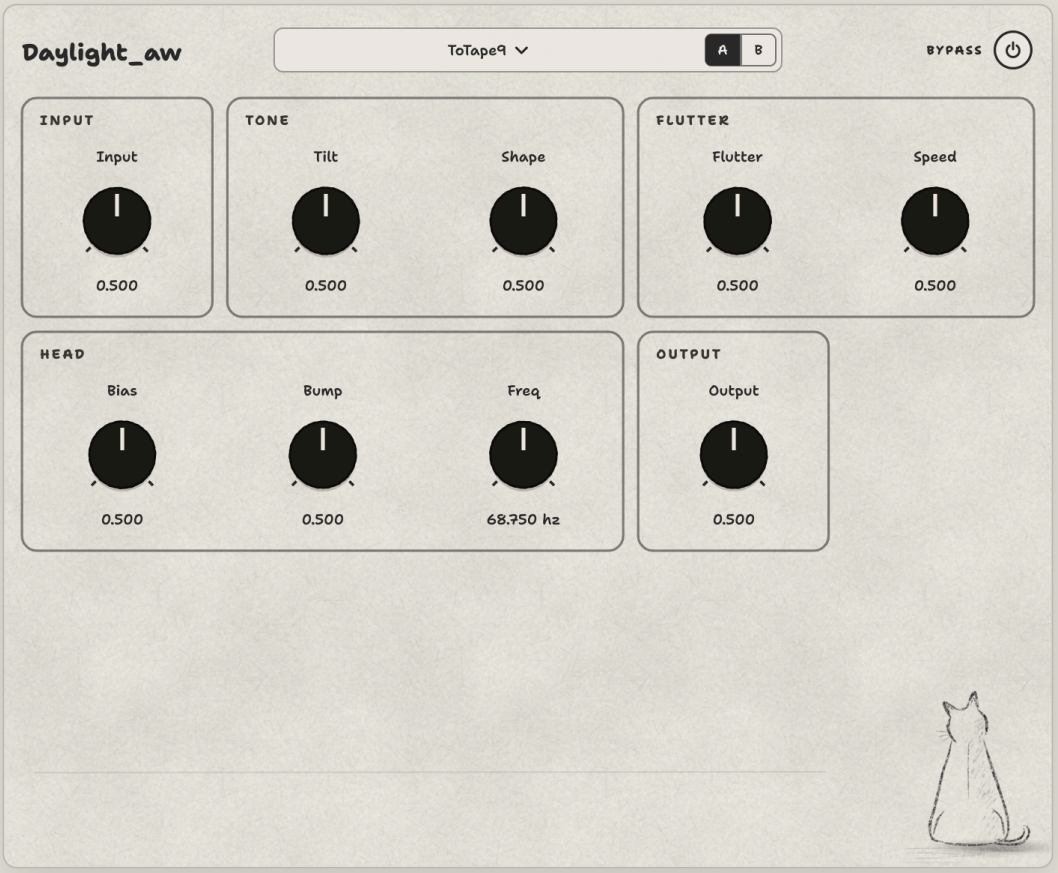
Daylight_aw

Original Airwindows effects in a calm, hand-drawn interface



Version 1.0 · User manual · by big_tyme_designs

At a glance

What	A free audio plugin that runs one original Airwindows effect per instance, in its own clear interface.
Sound	The original Airwindows code by Chris Johnson, unchanged. Automatic tests prove the output is bit-identical to the original plugin.
Effects	135 effects: the newest version of every Airwindows plugin Chris recommends, plus his latest releases (list at the end).
Formats	VST3 (Windows, macOS, Linux) and AU (macOS). 64-bit. Apple silicon and Intel.
Systems	Windows 10/11 · macOS 10.13 or newer · Linux x64 (Ubuntu 22.04 or similar and newer)
CPU	The same as the original Airwindows plugin. The interface only redraws what changes.
Price / licence	Free and open source (GNU AGPL v3). No account, no internet connection, no tracking.
Download	github.com/bigtymedesigns/daylight_aw → **Releases**

> Daylight_aw is **not an official Airwindows release**. All the sound is Chris Johnson's work: please support him at patreon.com/airwindows.

The idea

Airwindows plugins sound wonderful but come without a graphical interface: your DAW shows a row of plain sliders. Daylight_aw gives each effect a calm, readable interface, with related controls grouped, real parameter names and values, presets, A/B comparison and themes, without touching the sound.

- **One effect per instance.** Insert Daylight_aw, choose an effect, and that instance stays that effect. Want another effect? Insert another Daylight_aw.
- **Nothing added to the sound.** The optional input/output trims are switched off completely at 0 dB.
- **Safe sessions.** Your projects remember the effect, every setting, A/B, the trims and the preset name, and they reopen exactly as you left them.

Quick start

1. Install the plugin (next page) and rescan plugins in your DAW.
2. Insert **Daylight_aw** (by big_tyme_designs) on a track.
3. The effect list opens: pick a category or search, then click an effect.
4. Confirm **Load**. The window shows that effect's controls.
5. Turn the knobs. Click the effect name at the top for presets and settings.

Installation

Windows (VST3)

1. Close your DAW.
2. From the download zip, copy the folder `Daylight_aw.vst3` into `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\` (Windows asks for administrator permission).
3. Start the DAW and rescan plugins (REAPER: Options → Preferences → Plug-ins → VST → Re-scan).

macOS (AU + VST3)

1. Quit your DAW. Copy `Daylight_aw.component` to `~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/` and `Daylight_aw.vst3` to `~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/` (Finder: Go → Go to Folder).
2. If macOS blocks the plugin, open Terminal and run the two `xattr` lines from `INSTALL.txt` in the zip.
3. Restart the DAW and rescan (Logic: Settings → Plug-in Manager → Reset & Rescan).

Linux (VST3)

Copy `Daylight_aw.vst3` to `~/.vst3/` and rescan in your DAW.

Updating

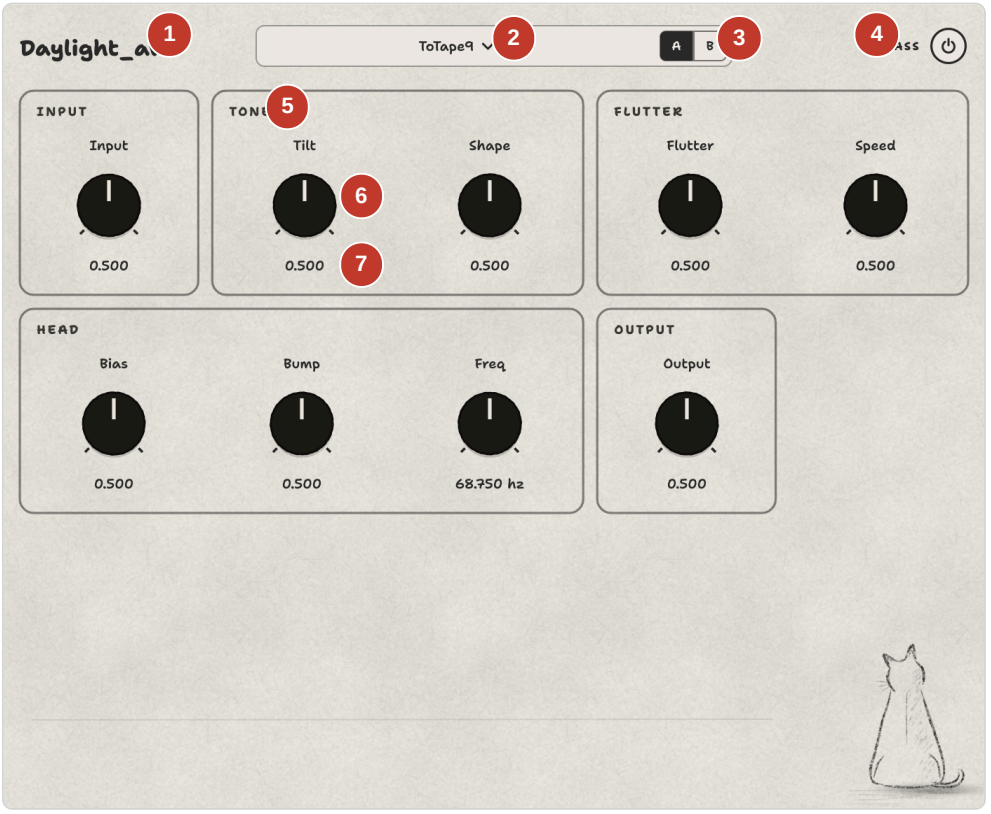
1. **Close your DAW completely** (Windows can't replace a plugin file that is still loaded).
2. Replace the old `Daylight_aw.vst3` (and on Mac `Daylight_aw.component`) with the new one.
3. Start the DAW. Your projects, presets, favourites, themes and layouts are kept: they live in your Documents folder, not in the plugin.

Updates only ever add effects. An effect is never removed or renamed, so older projects always open.

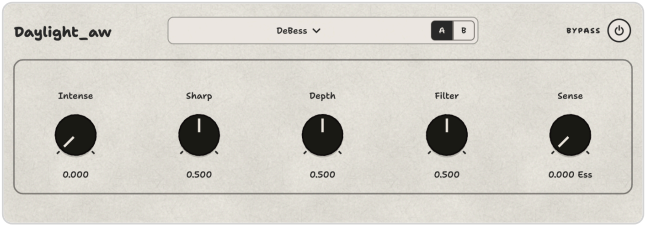
Uninstalling

Delete `Daylight_aw.vst3` (and `Daylight_aw.component` on Mac). To remove your own data too, delete the folder `Documents/big_tyme_designs/Daylight_aw`.

The window



1 Logo	Click for About: version, credits and licences.
2 Effect name	Click to open **presets and settings**. Shows the preset name, with ***** when you have changed something since loading it. Trim settings other than 0 dB are shown next to it (e.g. *IN +3.0*).
3 A / B	Two complete settings to compare. Switch with one click; both are saved with the project.
4 Bypass	The same switch as your DAW's bypass, with a short click-free fade.
5 Groups	Related controls framed together, named after what they do.
6 Controls	Knobs, stepped knobs (choices) and switches. See the next page.
7 Values	In the effect's own units where it has them (dB, Hz ...).



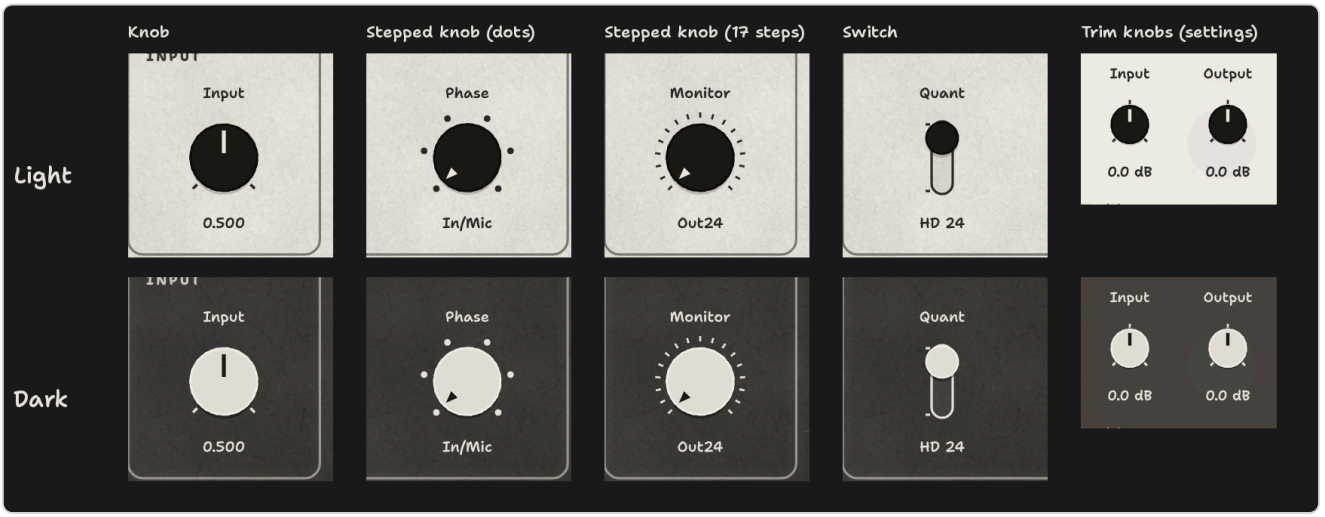
Effects with up to 5 controls use the small window.



Effects with 6 or more controls use the large window (here StoneFireComp in the Dark theme).

Controls and mouse

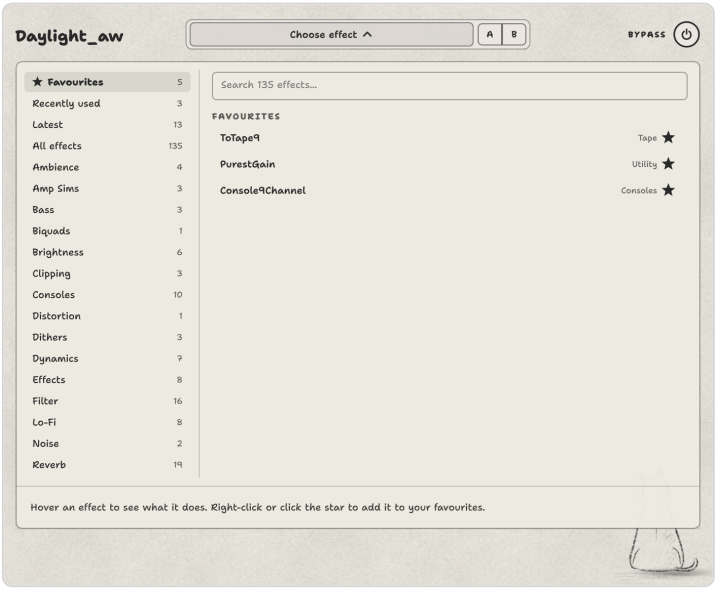
Do this	To
Drag up / down	Turn a knob (faders in the Original theme: drag sideways)
Shift + drag	Fine adjustment (10× finer)
Mouse wheel	Small steps (Shift: finer)
Double-click a knob	Back to the effect's default
Double-click the value	Type an exact value, Enter to confirm
Click a switch	Toggle it
Hover	Underlines the name and shows one more decimal; with tooltips on, a hint and the original Airwindows name



Knob, stepped knobs and switch in the Light and Dark themes, plus the trim knobs from Settings.

Everything is automatable. Your DAW shows the effect's real parameter names.

Choosing an effect



- **Favourites**: right-click an effect or click its star.
- **Recently used**: your last 10.
- **Latest**: the newest Airwindows releases (the 6 months before this Daylight_aw version).
- **All effects**, and Airwindows' own **categories**.
- **Search** looks in names and descriptions.
- Hover an effect to read what it does.

The choice is locked for that instance, so a project can never change sound by accident. Favourites and recently used are shared by every Daylight_aw instance.

Presets



- Click the effect name → **Save preset**, type a name, Enter.
- Click a preset to load it (into the current A or B).
- Right-click: rename, move to trash, show in folder.
- Presets are per effect, stored as small text files you can copy or share.
- Presets don't store trims or bypass.

Settings

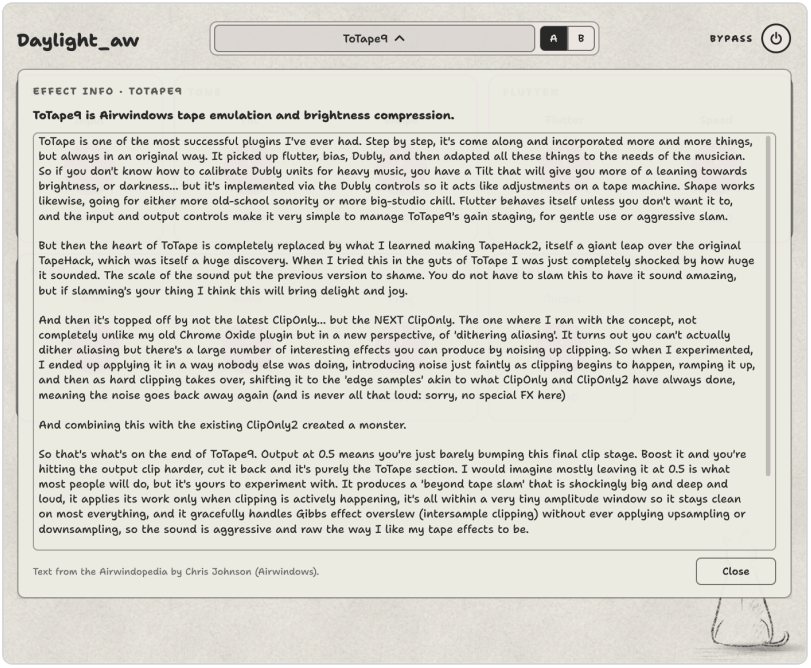
Zoom	100, 125, 150 or 200 % (for all instances).
Theme	**Light** (default), **Dark**, **Original** or **User**. The choice applies to every open instance.
Trims	Input trim (before the effect) and output trim (after it), ±12 dB, for gain staging. Double-click for 0 dB, where they are switched off completely. On dither effects, keep the output trim at 0 dB.
Tooltips	Off by default. Switch on for hints when hovering.
Reset to defaults	All controls back to the effect's defaults.
Effect info	The full Airwindopedia text by Chris about this effect.
Edit layout	Make your own layout (page "Make it yours").



Dark theme



Original theme: plain faders, Airwindows' own names and values, the computer's own font



Effect info: the Airwindopedia text for the effect.

Make it yours

Your own colours: the User theme

1. Settings → Theme → **User**, then **Open theme folder**.
2. Edit `theme.json` (colours like `"paper.color": "#E2DFD7"`) or replace `paper.png` / `figure.png`.
3. Save: the window updates within a second. Mistakes fall back to safe values, nothing can break.

Your own layouts

1. Open an effect → Settings → **Edit layout**. A file `<effect>.json` appears in the Layouts folder, as a copy of what you see.
2. Open it in any text editor: rename groups, move controls, change labels or control types. Save, and the window updates.
3. **Remove** goes back to the built-in layout. Typos are fixed automatically and every control always stays available.

Layout file example

```
{ "groups": [ { "title": "Tone", "controls": [ "Tilt", { "param": "HeadBmp", "label": "Bump" } ]
} ] }
```

Where your files are

What	Folder (inside `Documents/big_tyme_designs/Daylight_aw/`)
Presets	`Presets/<Effect>/<name>.dlpreset`
User theme	`Themes/User/`
Your layouts	`Layouts/<effect>.json`
Settings (theme, zoom, favourites)	`settings.json`

Back up this folder to keep everything when you move to a new computer.

Troubleshooting & FAQ

Daylight_aw doesn't show up	Check the plugin is in the right folder (page 3) and rescan. On Mac, run the `xattr` lines from INSTALL.txt.
"Access denied" when updating (Windows)	The DAW still has the plugin loaded. Close it completely; if needed end *reaper.exe* / *reaper_host* in Task Manager. No restart needed.
"This effect needs a newer Daylight_aw"	The project was saved with a newer version that has more effects. Update Daylight_aw. Until then audio passes through untouched and the settings are kept.
Does it sound exactly like the original?	Yes. Every effect is tested against the original code for bit-identical output (trims at 0 dB, not bypassed).
Can I change the effect of an instance?	No, by design: insert another Daylight_aw instead. This keeps projects safe.
Does it use the internet?	Never. No accounts, no update checks, no tracking.
Reverb tail cut off?	Reverbs report their tail to the DAW, so rendering and pausing keep it. If your DAW still cuts it, render with extra tail time.
Found a bug, or have an idea?	Open an **Issue** on the GitHub page. Effects, layouts and themes can also be contributed there (see CONTRIBUTING.md).

Legal & credits

- **Daylight_aw** © big_tyme_designs. Free software under the GNU Affero General Public License v3. The source code is at github.com/bigtymedesigns/daylight_aw. It comes **without any warranty**.
- **Airwindows** effects and Airwindopedia texts © Chris Johnson, MIT licence. Packaged via **Airwindows Consolidated** by Paul Walker (MIT). Daylight_aw is not an official Airwindows release.
- **JUCE** framework (AGPLv3). **VST** is a registered trademark of Steinberg Media Technologies GmbH. **Audio Units** and macOS are trademarks of Apple Inc.
- **Shantell Sans** font by Shantell Martin / Arrow Type, SIL Open Font Licence 1.1.
- Full licence texts: `LICENSE` and `THIRD_PARTY_NOTICES.md` in the download.

The effects (135)

Grouped by Airwindows category, alphabetically. Descriptions by Chris Johnson / Airwindows. Effects marked ★ are in the Latest folder.

Ambience

ClearCoat	ClearCoat is an array of bright ambience reverbs.
PitchDelay	PitchDelay is TapeDelay2 but with pitch shift instead of flutter.
TapeDelay2	TapeDelay2 is a new implementation of a flexible tape echo.
TripleSpread	TripleSpread is a stereo tripler with extra wideness and GlitchShifter processing.

Amp Sims

ChimeyDeluxe	ChimeyDeluxe is a very flexible compressed DI conditioner.
ChimeyGuitar2	ChimeyGuitar2 is a wilder ChimeyGuitar.
PointyGuitar	PointyGuitar is a supremely adaptable instrument amp.

Bass

DubSub2	DubSub2 is the essence of the Airwindows head bump.
Elliptical	Elliptical highpasses the side channel.
OrbitKick	OrbitKick is a bass generator and kick drum reinforcer.

Biquads

BiquadStack	BiquadStack is a way of making a parametric EQ out of stacked biquad filters.

Brightness

Air4	Air4 extends Air3 with controllable high frequency limiting.
DeBess	DeBess is an improved DeEss, with perfect rejection of non-ess audio.
Sinew	Sinew combines sines and slew clipping for a tape bias effect!
Slew4	Slew4 is tape compression without the tape, for brightness control.
SlewSonic	SlewSonic combines SlewOnly with ultrasonic filtering to solo brightness.
Smooth	Smooth can tame pointy sounds or make drums explode.

Clipping

ADClip9 ★	ADClip9 is the ClipOnly3 version of a loudenator/biggenator.
ClipOnly3	ClipOnly3 is just plain stinkin' loud.
OneCornerClip	OneCornerClip is an ultimate full-bandwidth clipper.

Consoles

Console0Buss	Console0Buss is a radical, minimalist Console system.
Console0Channel	Console0Channel is a radical, minimalist Console system.
Console9Buss	Console9Buss is just the summing from ConsoleX.
Console9Channel	Console9Channel is just the summing from ConsoleX.
ConsoleLABuss	ConsoleLABuss is the Airwindows take on the Quad Eight console.
ConsoleLAChannel	ConsoleLAChannel is the Airwindows take on the Quad Eight console.
ConsoleMCBuss	ConsoleMCBuss is the initial, bright take on the MCI console.
ConsoleMCChannel	ConsoleMCChannel is the initial, bright take on the MCI console.
PurestConsole3Buss	PurestConsole3Buss is an alternate algorithm for minimalist Console.
PurestConsole3Channel	PurestConsole3Channel is an alternate algorithm for minimalist Console.

Distortion

Mackity	Mackity is an emulation of the input stage of a vintage Mackie 1202!

Dithers

PaulDither	PaulDither is a highpassed TPDF dither. (quieter, airier)
PaulWide	PaulWide is a highpassed TPDF wide dither. (quieter, airier AND wider)
TPDFDither	TPDFDither is TPDF dither. With 16/24 bit output and a DeRez control.

Dynamics

BeziComp	BeziComp is a radical compressor that eliminates aliasing!
DigitalBlack	DigitalBlack is a quick, staccato gate.
Gatelope	Gatelope is a special gate that applies filters.
Pop3	Pop3 is the dynamics from ConsoleX.
Pyewacket	Pyewacket is an old school compressor for high definition transients. Adds no fatness, just energy.
SoftGate	SoftGate is a gate that can mute hiss and smooth sample tails.
StoneFireComp	StoneFireComp is some of the dynamics for ConsoleX.

Effects

Dubly3	Dubly3 refines and transforms the Dubly sound.
Energy2	Energy2 is electrifying fixed-frequency treble boosts for high sample rate.
GlitchShifter	GlitchShifter is a really gnarly, raw-sounding pitch shifter with a dose of insanity!
PitchNasty	PitchNasty is a primitive pitch shifter that also has primitive time-stretch artifacts.
TakeCare	TakeCare is a lush chorus ensemble universe.
Tremolo	Tremolo is fluctuating saturation curves for a tubey tremolo.
TremoSquare	TremoSquare is a squarewave tremolo effect that only switches on zero crossings.
Trianglizer	Trianglizer is a special waveshaper that can transform sines into triangles.

Filter

BezEQ3 ★	BezEQ3 refines the concept into four vivid, unified bands.
Dattorro	Dattorro is the resonant lowpass filter out of Donut.
Distance3	Distance3 combines the best parts of Distance and Discontinuity.
FastDistance ★	FastDistance is a sort of ultra-efficient lowpass filter.
FatEQ	FatEQ balances bands only with density.
Isolator3	Isolator3 is Isolator2, but on one slider, with a band-narrower control.
Parametric	Parametric is three bands of ConsoleX EQ in advance.
PearEQ	PearEQ is a six-band Pear-based graphic EQ.
PearLiteEQ	PearLiteEQ is a four-band Pear-based graphic EQ.
RetroBass ★	RetroBass is a special kind of highpass.
Silken	Silken is a high frequency boost that gives ambience and texture.
SmoothEQ3	SmoothEQ3 is the most approachable EQ.
Stonefire	Stonefire is the non-EQ EQ designed for ConsoleX.
Suzan ★	Suzan is a new type of ladder filter.
ToneSlant	ToneSlant is a super-transparent ‘tilt EQ’ with very low Q.
Weight	Weight is a very accurate sub-bass boost based on Holt.

Lo-Fi

CrunchyGrooveWear	CrunchyGrooveWear is a version of GrooveWear for more edge and distortion.
DeBez	DeBez gives you retro sampley textures!
DeRez5 ★	DeRez5 adds new forms of derezzing.
Flutter2	Flutter2 is the flutter from ToTape7, standalone.
GrooveWear	GrooveWear is for scrubbing highs off mechanically like a stylus would.
HipCrush	HipCrush is the de-rez section for ConsoleH.
Pockey2	Pockey2 is more efficient, more intense lo-fi hiphop in a plugin.
Vibrato	Vibrato lets you vibrato, chorus, flange, and make odd FM noises.

Noise

DeNoise	DeNoise can work as a multiband gate and as a wild effect.
TapeDust	TapeDust is just a special treble-erode noise, a ‘slew noise’ plugin.

Reverb

Chamber2	Chamber2 is a feedforward reverb, a blur delay, and a glitch topping!
CreamCoat	CreamCoat is a swiss army knife reverb with soft undersampling.
CrunchCoat	CrunchCoat is a cursed retro digital reverb!
Galactic3	Galactic3 is exactly Galactic again, but with better undersampling.

kAlienSpaceship	kAlienSpaceship is an unreal realistic reverb.
kBeyond	kBeyond is a recital hall.
kCathedral5	kCathedral5 lets you place yourself anywhere you like in the space.
kCosmos	kCosmos is infinite space ambient, or titanic hall.
kCyberCity ★	kCyberCity brings live atmosphere to deep reverb.
kGuitarHall2	kGuitarHall2 puts things in a Loud Room.
kPlate140	kPlate140 is a next-generation Airwindows plate reverb.
kPlate240	kPlate240 is for the texture of smaller, gold foil reverb.
kRockstar2 ★	kRockstar2 is a realistic hall reverb using a new matrix!
kStation	kStation is a realistic small room modeled after David Bowie's vocal reverb.
kWoodRoom	kWoodRoom is a small wooden performing space.
NonlinearSpace	NonlinearSpace is a flexible reverb plugin.
Ultralight2 ★	Ultralight2 is more of the most low-CPU matrix reverb I can make.
VerbSevens ★	VerbSevens is a calibrated reference reverb plugin for reverb matrices.
VerbTiny	VerbTiny is a classic artificial reverb that expands reverb shape.

Saturation

Hypersoft	Hypersoft is a more extreme form of soft-clipper.
Longhand ★	Longhand is an experiment in softclipping.
Tube2	Tube2 extends Tube, with more sophisticated processing and input trim.

Stereo

Srsly3	Srsly3 is Srsly2, with a Nonlin control to analogify the filters.
ToVinyl4	ToVinyl4 is a vinyl-mastering simulator bringing several vinyl-type colors.
Wider	Wider is Airwindows stereo space shaping.

Subtlety

Discontapeity	Discontapeity combines air modeling with tape-style overdrive.
Discontinuity	Discontinuity models air under intense loudness.
Inflamer	Inflamer is an Airwindowsized take on the waveshapers in Oxford Inflator.
Mastering2	Mastering2 is Airwindows style, and can do elliptical EQ now!
PurestWarm3 ★	PurestWarm3 is a subtle tone shaper and warmth adder.
Shape	Shape is an asymmetrical waveshaper for peak manipulating.
SingleEndedTriode	SingleEndedTriode is unusual analog modeling effects.
Sweeten	Sweeten is where you can find super-clean second harmonic.

Tape

TapeHack2	TapeHack2 brings Airwindows tape to a new level.
ToTape9	ToTape9 is Airwindows tape emulation and brightness compression.

Tone Color

ChannelX ★	ChannelX translates Channel9 into a profusion of wild experiments.

Utility

BitShiftPan	BitShiftPan gives you a gain and a pan control that are ONLY done using bit shifts.
Cans	Cans is a room simulator for headphone mixers.
CansAW	CansAW is Chris's Airwindows room, in a plugin, for headphone mixers.
DubPlate2	DubPlate2 is like an ITB mastering house for electronic music.
Golem	Golem lets you blend a stereo track of two mics on an amp.
Monitoring3	Monitoring3 is Monitoring, but with Ten Nines into Dark as the wordlength reducer.
PurestDualPan	PurestDualPan is an updated PurestGain but as a dual pan.
PurestFade	PurestFade is just like PurestGain, but for LONG fades.
PurestGain	PurestGain is a high-res noise shaped gain, with smoothed fader.
SoftClock3	SoftClock3 is a groove-oriented time reference.

XY2 Filters

XBandpass	XBandpass is a distorted digital EQ, inspired by retro sampler DSP.
XHighpass	XHighpass is a distorted digital EQ, inspired by retro sampler DSP.
XLowpass	XLowpass is a distorted digital EQ, inspired by retro sampler DSP.
XNotch	XNotch is a distorted digital EQ, not as glitchy as the others.
XRegion	XRegion is distorted staggered bandpasses, for extreme soundmangling.
YBandpass	YBandpass is soft and smooth to nasty, edgy texture-varying filtering.
YHighpass	YHighpass is soft and smooth to nasty, edgy texture-varying filtering.
YLowpass	YLowpass is soft and smooth to nasty, edgy texture-varying filtering.
YNotch	YNotch is soft and smooth to nasty, edgy texture-varying filtering.
ZBandpass2	ZBandpass2 acts more like the Emu e6400 Ultra bandpass in motion, with control smoothing.
ZHighpass2	ZHighpass2 acts more like the Emu e6400 Ultra highpass in motion, with control smoothing.
ZLowpass2	ZLowpass2 acts more like the Emu e6400 Ultra lowpass in motion, with control smoothing.
ZNotch2	ZNotch2 acts more like the Emu e6400 Ultra phaser in motion, with control smoothing.
ZRegion2	ZRegion2 is an Emu e6400 style Airwindows Region filter, with control smoothing.